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Daryl Sherman

Daryl Sherman has fashioned a robust career as a vocalist, pianist, and distinctive song stylist. Her combination of musical skills have enabled her to work steadily in the competitive New York City music scene.

Daryl was interviewed via Zoom on June 11, 2024 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Daryl Sherman with me this morning, pianist and vocalist and owner of something that a lot of musicians would be envious of.

DS: Really?

MR: It's not your piano, although I wouldn't mind having that piano, but really what I'm referring to is you have a steady gig.

DS: Well a lot of people have a steady gig but yes. And I started having steady gigs when I moved here. And it wasn't until later that I understood what a one-nighter was about. I got spoiled very early on. But if you want me to tell you about this gig, it's kind of funny that it should come to this, but I couldn't be more grateful. It is a building atrium on Park Avenue between 52nd and 53rd, and all of those buildings are banks and usually really high-end investment companies and then restaurants, but mostly very upscale take-out places with fancy cartons that you can take your food back to the office or sit on a low table and chairs that my building, Park Avenue Plaza, offers. The history to the music there is thanks to Barry Singer who is the proprietor (I like that word), of the most charming and sophisticated bookstore, Chartwell, and they specialize in Winston Churchill. And he's himself quite an intellect and a real New Yorker who loves jazz and has befriended so many great jazz musicians like Dick Katz, and he's had a piano, a solo piano for well over twenty years. The last person before me was Chuck Folds who was an elegant gentleman and a marvelous pianist and an intellect from the Midwest originally, playing lots of stride piano and Louis Armstrong and I think the thing he loved the most was playing with Doc Cheatham down in the Village regularly off the steady gig on Sundays. Chuck Folds.

MR: Is it a jazz gig or is it — or do you play to what you perceive —

DS: Yes.

MR: Okay.

DS: Yes.

MR: That's an interesting process to look around the room and you see somebody and it's almost like, "I think I know what they want to hear."

DS: Or should hear.

MR: Should. Well said.

DS: I started playing as much Fats Waller as I could, and I have a few things that — I knew Dick Wellstood and I know enough about stride playing to know that I could never pull it off, it's just too many notes and you know, too much precision. And — but later on he was really getting into the American Songbook and he brought songbooks with him. I used to go hear him a lot. And Sinatra. And particularly in this day and age post-pandemic and whatever, it's kind of a challenge insofar as just bringing people back to the office during the day. So many people are working from home and you know, clearly there are people who are still in the office but not as many as there used to be. And it's — you just never know who's — oh and the reason I didn't even realize how many atriums there were, particularly in this area, that had a piano I guess for the reason that it's the owner's way of giving back to the City because they got a tax break to build that building and there's a public restroom, they've got a Starbucks, you know they do provide some table and chairs and in some cases a live person. But what I do now is, as you said, kind of case out who's there and just the vibe. Even though I start at twelve I start with [sings] "Oh What a Beautiful Morning" and I go to, "I Love Being Here with You." And other things I do for the most part these people are so young now they don't really know from Peggy Lee necessarily, but I do notice that they know "From the Vine" or just something lilting. And I'm not singing. This is — at first this was kind of the hardest part for me. I've done solo piano gigs and I've done long term hotel gigs. Fourteen years at The Waldorf. On and off probably about the same amount of time at The Sheridan Center. And I know when you can just sit and be a jazz player and I know when you have to play to the audience, which is fine because it's a way of relating and building relationships and it's the best way to build a repertoire. I'm having fun. When I see people walk in [sings] "Walk right in, sit right down. Baby let —"

MR: Nice. What do you do if someone comes up to you and requests something from "Kinky Boots" or Taylor Swift or —

DS: I just mentioned to someone, I'm at a loss, I have to admit. Just, even older shows, I have something, probably one of the most enduring Broadway shows is "Wicked" and I saw it and I did understand why it should endure, because the kids can connect and it is interesting to learn what the wicked witch used to be, and she wasn't really wicked. And then I loved it. And I've heard the song a zillion times. There are songs like that from these pop shows I cannot remember. They just sound all the same. You know I can play two or three bars. But sometimes that's enough.

MR: Yes, that's right.

DS: As long as they hear something they recognize.

MR: That's right, and you can sort of improvise in the fashion and make it at least 24 bars or something.

DS: Yeah.

MR: Just keep playing a lick from the tune.

DS: I play some — I studied classical music. I was not a music major but I studied piano all through college. And my shining hour was, you know, a couple of Chopin etudes and scherzos and when I was in college, because the best thing that happened to me was a practice room in a building away from anything to distract me. And I can't believe that I was able to practice and learn and memorize these things. But after that I really knew, and even my teacher knew that Beethoven, Bach and I were not wed and that I was much more into Ellington. But I still think it was the most important thing I could do and I loved playing them and I pull out a few things to do and the Gershwin preludes and now I've really gotten — I figure I can do this because you know there — I'm very sad about — well I'm nervous, in a few days I will turn a gulp — a really gulp age. I'm in good company because we baby boomers are very special, but nonetheless it is wigging me out.

MR: Well you're going to be playing on your birthday, right?

DS: What?

MR: You're going to be playing on your birthday, right?

DS: Yes. I booked a gig at Mezzrow last year and it was a mistake. Because no matter how many years I've played and just, you know, it should be just like the most natural thing to do, I still get nervous, maybe even more nervous organizing the music, making the last minute choices. "What were you thinking, Daryl? You can't play that song." Things like that. And even more important on my birthday, food. It's a tradition, Peking Duck and here's another issue — we're going from issues to issues — hard to find a Chinese restaurant since the pandemic. They started to leave, well come on, Chinese restaurants, Wuhan. The people were already scared to death. And the main thing in all of the restaurants — not enough help. They don't have anyone who wants to stay late. And that was the problem for my birthday last year, I could not find a place, including the Peking Duck House in the Village. And there's one in my neighborhood on 53rd Street, so I had to completely change my plans, order take-out and have it at a friend's house. And they delivered the Peking Duck and all that stuff. But you know what? It was fun, it was nice, but it's not the same. You have to be there.

MR: How do you keep a steady gig? I think that's just basically my question. Or maybe I can turn it around.

DS: By, you know first of all by getting a steady gig like here's a case in point: The Waldorf. And I remember the day so well. I have to get this in. '94 I was doing my first show with

Marian McPartland recording at the studio down in the West 30s, and but I was younger then so I wasn't as crazy and nervous as I am now, so I did that but also just before I left I got a call from an agent who booked The Waldorf asking me if I could go in and play, apparently the piano was in the middle of the lobby at that point. And I said, "Okay, sure, fine." So after I did her show, and it was the first one where — her format you know of course. There's two pianos, she talks, we gab a little bit and then she makes it sound like we're doing it like just off the cuff but of course — "So what should we do for the second song?" You know it's very organized. Well, not the actual playing but at least the order. So after all that I go to The Waldorf and I play in the lobby the Cole Porter piano. I'm not even sure if I sang because I don't even remember if they had a microphone. Maybe they did. Come to find out that a very good singer/pianist I knew, a colleague, whatever she did it's one of those things where the general manager had walked by, noticed her, and then gave the directive, "She's got to go." Now she was, she was a bit kooky, she wore hats and she had long nails and a little eccentric. Whatever it was I feel bad for her although she moved south and she did very well after that. But I got hired. It was like a paid audition, and then I was there for fourteen years. So to answer your actual question, a combination of things. Maybe prepare and bring some things in that you want to play and maybe something you're going to read, you know, depending on if no one's paying attention that's a good time to do that. And you try to have some prep on who this crowd is. They're probably — at like The Sheridan Center I was right across the street from the show "Cats." That was, you know, the theater district. And I actually, I actually told the actress who sang it every night, I said, "I sing this song eight times in a five hour gig, every night." [sings] "Midnight —" so yeah, you've got to be prepared for that. It depends on the place. In The Waldorf I was up in the Cocktail Terrace, that's what they called it, and it was the main entrance of the beautiful art deco lobby. Who knows what it's going to be like. It has been many years now just in construction. The rumor is it's planning to open again soon. But during that time I was — actually right playing and below was the main entrance, One Park Avenue. People would come in and go through that way, and then the Lexington Avenue entrance people might come through. Some would stay but it was a really good place to go across, particularly if you're going to Grand Central Station. You go through the Waldorf and then you get to the stop. So I had a relationship just with people coming either from Lexington to Park, looking up and waving, or Park to Lexington. I had a relationship with the staff. Everything from the bartenders, some of the managers, and more interesting, the people who were there in security or someone who — she had the most gorgeous face — who was polishing the railing of the staircases. Brass railing and stuff, you know, every day. I mean it was such a whole other world.

MR: I know what you're talking about. It's interesting to sit in a place for four hours or something and who watches their hands when they play? Not many people. So you can look around the room and just make these observations. And —

DS: Oh yeah. Oh, oh — we piano players observe everything. And we're ready. You know in the old days when the mob owned a lot of the clubs, which is really something that we miss in this business. Those clubs are gone, like Jilly's. That's where I started. Jimmy Weston's — and all over the country there were always places like that, but you also knew to duck when somebody dangerous was coming in, to hide under the piano.

MR: Don't shoot the piano player.

DS: But at The Waldorf I would have a big mixture, a lot of Europeans at the time I was there The Waldorf had a deal with Cunard and at the time it was — I guess it was the Queen Elizabeth was docking and most of them stayed at The Waldorf. That was really helpful to me because once I started performing more in England it was really a nice way to see them and have them help me to fill the audience. But from all countries, and local New Yorkers coming in and knowing, well and even visitors. There was a plaque that was engraved that Cole Porter lived in The Waldorf Towers and he wrote some of America's most popular songs and blah-blah-blah. And I always tell this — people would come in sometimes and they look at that, I mean it was really a little bit of a tourist attraction, look at me, and look at the sign again, and say, "Well is he going to come down and play?" And then I have to tell them the bad news. I didn't always want to tell them he died so I'd tell them, "He's playing a bar mitzvah."

MR: He's decomposing. Okay I want to take you back a bit and I'm going to do that by seeing if you can name this tune. All right? I'll give it my best rendition. [scats]

DS: [sings] "perhaps someone else may be nearer/your heart." Interesting that you should do that one. It's not one — it's not necessarily a staple that I have played throughout, and I'm not even sure I can recall that many people asking for it, but it was a song that I sang a lot in my home in Woonsocket, Rhode Island, and I probably heard it on the radio or on the many recordings that my father would play. My father, Sammy, was a trombonist and although he was mainly working in our family restaurant, on the weekends he usually would have some kind of a steady weekend gig with his band and that was my first most important mentorship. And I was told I could sing before I could talk and there was — we didn't have a real piano but there was some keyboard that he had that I started to fiddle with. But he then encouraged me when we got — and I used to call it a "junky upright" to play, this is probably even before I was taking lessons and he had — he always would write out some songs that he would play on his gigs. They were always standards, and he would write the melody line and chords, although the melody was

written in the trombone bass line. But I don't think that was one of them. The one that I remember, and I never sing it it's too rangy, is "I'll Get By."

MR: I see.

DS: [sings] "I'll get by as long as I have you." And I didn't know anything from Billie Holiday at that time, but the songs I did, and "Once in a While" I sang it, I knew it, I liked it.

MR: Well I —

DS: I don't even remember, who do you like singing it? Because who had the big hit on it? I don't even know.

MR: I don't remember but the reason — I have to give you my in, in that a fellow named Bob Jacobson wrote an article about you.

DS: He did. He's from Providence.

MR: In the Woonsocket publication.

DS: Oh, oh, oh right.

MR: Remember that? It was some years ago.

DS: Oh I remembered. And he mentioned "Once in a While?"

MR: Yes he did. He also mentioned a couple of other tunes that you sang before, as you said, before you could really talk. So I'll send you a link to the article. You should read about yourself.

DS: I'm sure he sent it to me. Is he a fan of yours?

MR: Well he is helping out with these interviews. He lives in — he does some proofreading for us, and very knowledgeable.

DS: Oh.

MR: So I was wondering, you almost casually mentioned that you're more nervous now than when you were young. And when I think about the names that I've seen, the people that you've met and associated with, I remember feeling nervous around those kinds of people because you just felt like these folks are on another level and I want to make sure that I don't sort of do anything wrong.

DS: Aw. Yeah.

MR: Milt Hinton and that crowd of people just seemed to have the kind of character that you want to emulate.

DS: Well that time, that was in the '70s, and I had just moved here to 49th Street and I was so lucky because two of the best places for me as a singer and pianist were right within reach, that one on 55th just off Third Avenue, and then the other one Jimmy Weston's, where I did get to work but I believe Gil Wiest is still alive, in his 90s, living out in Santa Monica. He was quite a character, not a kissy-huggy person at all but he had one of the best clubs going, and it was in the period of, I didn't realize it at the time 'cause — but

the Mad Men. He had that kind of crowd to come in and just eat the food and pay for the entertainment whether they cared about who was playing or not. And then he had all these jazz all-stars and I, sitting at the bar with a bartender who used to work on 52nd Street already getting my vibe and taking care of me, and always having a check near the one drink that I would have, so the boss would think that I was still drinking you know, and allowing me to sit there all night, and eventually, for whatever reason, when Gil Wiest saw me there and he heard I was a singer and pianist, he let me — oh actually — it didn't just come from Gil Wiest, it was Dave McKenna who worked there. So first, I mean before I met and got to know Milt it was Dave McKenna, my own hometown hero who I'd never met. I was very close with his family, particularly his sister, who sang with my father's band. And we are still very close. And Dave just by his nature and knowing my dad actually asked me if I wanted to sit in on the second set. I did, Gil heard me, and allowed me, when there was somebody who might be, you know, who was embracing enough to want to ask me, so that started it. But Dave introduced me — all the musicians in town came to hear him through the week or two, however long he was there. All of them. I met John Bunch. I don't know I don't think Milt was playing with Dave but Milt would be there and that's how I got to know him. He was working with somebody else, I can't remember who worked with who but Red Norvo —

MR: When you sat in, were you sitting in as a pianist or —

DS: Oh no, singer.

MR: Or both — as a singer. So you're singing, and Dave was accompanying.

DS: Oh yeah, yeah.

MR: Which leads me to something I wanted to make sure we talk about, the sometimes mysterious art of accompaniment. And what makes a good accompanist? I was listening to a video of you singing "I'm Shadowing You" and it occurred to me what a wonderful thing it is to be able to accompany yourself. Because you can do like instant arrangements.

DS: Thank you. Yes. And, but it's a wonderful thing but it's also, you know I'm now too easily into that in everything I do it's all of the moment. And being at that daily place where I have the freedom to play a Beatles song and then Art Tatum something, or whatever, same thing. And I never play anything the same way twice. So I'm reinforcing that and I don't think I'm going to get too structured anymore but yes. But I — and it took a while because I really didn't hear that much growing up in Woonsocket I heard some great musicians and I sang with my dad's band which consisted of a great guitarist, his name was Alvin Pulley, and his regular keyboard was an accordion player who was also a professor at Providence College and he taught Old English.

MR: Old English.

DS: Chaucer. Chaucer. But he also was not playing "Lady of Spain" he was one of the first to get those — all those new-fangled things that the accordions were able to do — yeah, like a computer. Almost like an electric piano. So he had one of those and he wasn't a jazz player but he could play really good harmony on the accordion and that's what I got used to, singing. And later on my father encouraged me to accompany myself and sing with myself. So I had both.

MR: Do you think you accompany significantly differently when you accompany another singer?

DS: I love doing that actually. With good singers. And I am careful, I mean I know Mike Renzi and all the people out there now that people use. But I pride myself in thinking that I know to stay out of their way. I don't have the chops to play in every key faking it and playing a lot of full fingers all the time. But for a singer and then for accompanying myself, that's not mostly what you want. Sometimes it's nice, lots of arpeggios and things, and I think even fine pianists that I've heard don't realize that they should stay out of the singer's register. If I hear that the tone quality or where, you know, where in the song they're singing I'll go up and I'll add something there. I actually think of myself more on the keyboard as a painter. I don't have — I'm never going to stun anybody with my amazing technique flying up and down, but it's the choices you make and I'm into colors and I'm finding even more now that I'm playing this piano, and it's not a Steinway, it's called a Young Chang, it's a Korean piano and they're trying to be a little less expensive of a Yamaha, which is less expensive than a Steinway. The wood is heavier and clunky. But this particular piano has a very lovely ringing sound which is perfect for that building. And I'm loving how I can paint and play something up there for a minute and come down. And I see that people respond. So in accompanying a singer also I have the advantage over even some pianists who do accompany singers because they don't always know the words but I do know the words and I know what they mean and even if the singer doesn't know what it means yet, I can pull them into that direction.

MR: What a wonderful statement.

DS: So I do like to play for singers.

MR: Yeah. One of the things that I've noticed recently with the advent of iRealPro where people are playing — you can get the chords to just about any song you want on your phone. But it's only the chords. It doesn't have the melody.

DS: Oh God, I know.

MR: So if you're accompanying a singer, unless you really know this song, you don't know what pitches they're singing and I find that really sort of false.

DS: Well don't get me started on this whole century. Because I'm glad I'm here, I make the best of it, I try, you know I try to get into the advanced things but I really don't get it.

Although I do appreciate the technology and I appreciate the skill that it takes to manipulate it and what they can do, but I am on the fence. I am seeing more and more people even my age using them. My bass player, one of my steady bass players, Boots Malison, a wonderful, wonderful musician, says that some of his, he calls them "accounts" some of his accounts hand out not music, they hand out an iPad just for this musician for the show. I mean like five iPads they bring to the gig. But I remember — this sticks in my mind going back home to Rhode Island and singing with one of my quote mentors, not as well known as Mike Renzi, he — in his way — totally different. Much more of a groove player like Junior Mance. He loved Junior Mance.

MR: Oh Junior Mance.

DS: Yeah. He's like that, and — but very flexible. And he helped me get started before I left for New York and helped me — well first he invited me to sing with his trio right in the middle of Newport, and then helped me to find a couple of gigs where I was singing and playing piano by myself. Anyway, years later I'm on a gig with him. They're always doing a special jazz Sunday or so, blah-blah-blah. And suddenly he's got — it's not I don't think, no it wasn't an iPad, not yet, but just a phone. And he was reading the chord changes. And I said to myself Mac Chrupcala never needed to do that. Never. I was spoiled even coming to New York calling a well known standard not in the original key, and most of them could do it. They weren't shuffling through their phones.

MR: I played at a jam session the other day and I could tell the audience needed to hear something familiar so I called "Watermelon Man." And these musicians I was playing with all got out their phones. I'm thinking for "Watermelon Man" you need —? I mean, like you said —

DS: Don't get me started, I could just go on and on about this, and yet here I am already thinking I saw an ad that if you get a better iPhone we'll throw in an iPad so I'm thinking about it.

MR: Have you ever had an instance where you really want to give some advice, and I'll give an example. I've done a lot of restaurant playing and so forth and I've had circumstances where someone would come up and say, "Do you mind if I sing a tune with you?" And you go, okay. First of all it's like well what would you like to sing. And they'll go "Well I don't know what do you know?" And then oh boy. And then, or they'll say, I'll say, "How about 'Summertime?'" And they go, "Oh okay." And you go, "Well what key do you like?" And they go, well here's my first note [sings a note].

DS: Oh yeah, I guess all right, it's universal. It's universal.

MR: Don't you want to say something to them like —

DS: My father all those years ago, when I was like eight and nine or twelve, "Don't be" you know, "Don't be like all those people who —" and he just did exactly what you said.

Amateurs. "Don't be an amateur. You need to know your keys and tell them you're going to do it in this key and you're going to go back to the bridge and then you're going to take it out." And he showed me all the terms. And, "You know, Cookie," (he called everybody Cookie but I was number one Cookie) "Cookie, I must talk to you about your vibrato. You're getting a nanny. Oh he should hear me now.

MR: You're getting a nanny?

DS: But you know that stuff still happens. And you know what? I am the most exposed now in this afternoon gig. There's no sign — I haven't — I could have asked them to put a sign here with my name and maybe I will now that I've had this interview and I'm going to be famous I'm going to put a sign on the piano. But first I'm going to — people come up, "Oh isn't this nice that you have a piano here. Can I play?"

MR: Ooh.

DS: It happens so much and that's part of the reason they have security people around of course, although there's never one when you need it, they just happen to pass. And they say, you know, they just think oh isn't this nice, how often are you here? You don't get paid for this, do you? I say, "You bet your ass I do."

MR: Yeah, they might think that oh this piano here is for people walking through to play.

DS: And then I say maybe I should have a little promo that says where I've worked for fifty years. It happens, yeah, it happens.

MR: So I know you know Nicki Parrott.

DS: Oh. They went down under, back to Aussie.

MR: Yes she did. I miss her. She's played up here on occasion and — I want to read a very brief quote from my interview with Nicki. And this is when she was younger, and she said, "I was so conscious of being taken seriously. There was one instance when I got called for a gig and they said, 'Is this Nick Parrott?' I said, 'Well actually it's Nicki.' And the person said, 'A bass player?' 'Yeah, Nicki Parrott.' Click." Phone hangs up. Have you ever had that happen to you?

DS: Oh sure. A lot of people — first of all I knew — I was seeing her more often in the days when Arbors had those wonderful jazz parties in Florida, and then of course she moved to New York and we've done some gigs together and she was just starting to sing then. And I feel so complimented now because she said, "Oh Daryl, you're a real singer." Well look what's happened. Look what happened to her. Just, well, because of the name, particularly if they don't — oh, here's a good story. Here's a good story: One summer in the '80s Dave McKenna first of all was playing at the Copley Plaza which was the best gig. He was playing solo, they gave him a room upstairs, bathtubs were big, he loved it. He was in heaven. However, he wanted to have a summer off to play in the Cape for whatever reason, and I got asked to play. I can't believe it. Even now I can't believe it.

And I was there for at least a couple of summers. But okay, first of all, it's Boston, that was a busy hotel then, and it was Dave's room and the bar was filled with I could see, I know the type. A lot of them were Madison Avenue types in New York at the bar talking amongst themselves, and I was at the — I guess to the entrance of the room and I go to like the side part of the bar before I'm starting. And I hear the discussion. "So who the hell is this guy Daryl somebody or other who thinks he can play Dave's piano. What nerve." And I swear to you it's true, this is how it happened. And I'm just standing there. So I wait, they're going on and on and then finally I just go — and I just walk to the piano and I sit down and start playing. And the room is silent. And it took a while. It took a while. They wouldn't even come near me. But you know what? I managed to win some of them over and when they knew that I adored Dave, that we had so much, you know, family in common and lucky for me one of his staples, because that was what was so wonderful about Dave McKenna, he could play any jazz song and he could play standards and he could play Bobby Short songs or any oddball things. "Sand in My Shoes."

MR: I pulled out a quote from him, from his interview, that he said, "I'm more of a song player than a jazz player."

DS: Yes. And I cry when I think about it. He can just play two measures of an introduction, just that, maybe three, and he is already inside the song. And yes, that's what makes him so extraordinary. And just he didn't brag about it, it was just who he was, just who he was, all those songs. "Dream Dancing" yeah. So anyway as far as Daryl is concerned, it still happens.

MR: Do you have a sense of, especially on this type of gig you're doing now, that people are going to enjoy what you play more if you make the melody predominant, like they're used to hearing it sung? And the reason I ask that is I've heard some piano players who will take a song like "Spanish Eyes," which has a certain groove to it, and they'll just like be so — first rubato and then florid and all this stuff until it doesn't even matter that the song is "Spanish Eyes"?

DS: Understand. I understand what you're saying. In my case in this particular venue, where people are just walking in and out and sometimes there's hardly anybody there, I could do, you know, fifty choruses of what I think is "Spanish Eyes" but no one else would recognize it. And sometimes it probably is just as well because it just sounds nice and it's elevator music, you know, it really is. But in general I definitely try — and actually here is another, well secret or a confession, most of my performances through the years is singing along with my playing, maybe playing solos here and there which I would enjoy, but it's still the singing. So this is, now it's been over two years of just piano, and I really didn't give it that much thought when I took the job and started playing. And I started

playing all these songs that I know and then suddenly every once in a while you know it's like my fingers are like going to a note pattern and my fingers are just going to wrong notes and I'm realizing, Daryl, you never played the melody in all these years if you're accompanying yourself. So number one give yourself a break. Don't feel bad about it because it's amazing that you can do it. Actually I do amaze myself and then I play it in all different keys.

MR: Yes I noticed —

DS: And mostly my fingers are doing more for me than any other part of my body right now.

MR: Oh that's a good statement. That's right. Your fingers almost sense okay I know this has got to go up the scale or there's this little leap here.

DS: You just go there. I don't know how it happens I swear to you I don't know. It's divine intervention, but it has then made me aware of that so I'm using this to play all of these and try them in different keys and all of a sudden realizing well I always played it in that key because my vocal range, it suited that — but oh listen to how beautiful the melody sounds in this register, because I'm a painter. So I'm having a good time, and it's — and you know I'm at this [gulp] age but I'm not dead and I'm still learning and loving it.

MR: Well that says a lot. Now do you like to listen back to your own recordings?

DS: At first no, and now I'm glad you asked because I'm not much for — I don't want an Alexa. I don't want her to hear — Alexa? You know what I mean?

MR: I do.

DS: Okay. And I say, "Alexa, play Daryl Sherman" almost every night now because I'm realizing I'm getting royalties. And I have to confess I'm astounded. Wow. Because it goes on and on all night and it's never repeating anything. I'm — so it makes — it really makes me feel wow, this is my legacy. And it's — the sound that I have for that is not a very clear sound so, you know, it could sound a lot better, but just the fact of all the songs and the different musicians that I played with. And when you hear it all mixed up, I have to tell you, it's really adding life to me.

MR: I'm so happy to hear you say that.

DS: I can't believe it. But the other problem is everything that I'm really excited about has already happened.

MR: One never knows, do one.

DS: Well now I mean I'm still playing jazz clubs. I just, in April I went to my bottom file cabinet, got out my Mildred Bailey music and remembered that I had done a very special event in her home state of Washington, Spokane and Tekoa, which is a tribal, a tribal lands where she grew up. And I asked Loren Schoenberg — are you familiar with him? I knew you would be, very important in our jazz world. He's so busy teaching and conducting bands, he's, and he was Bobby Short's music director at one time. But I

talked him into doing that with me and not only playing alto — excuse me, tenor sax — which he doesn't get to do as often, but he's a marvelous pianist. So he did both. He played piano for me. I also played as well. That took some doing, just figuring out how to get on and off the piano bench, but we did it. And I had James Chirillo on guitar and Boots Malison on bass and it was so wonderful to give those songs a dust-off and get to talk about her a little bit. And on the opening night from the State of Washington I think probably her only living relative, her niece, came, Julia Rinker, who was the daughter of Al Rinker, who was one of the Rhythm Boys with Bing Crosby for Paul Whiteman.

MR: Wow.

DS: Yeah. And she got up and talked a little bit and she sang a song that her father had written. So it was so special.

MR: You know you answered a question of mine, I was going to ask in your memory what comes through as one of your best gigs ever and one of your worst gigs ever? So you did talk about, "Who's this Daryl person that's going to play Dave's piano." And then you just mentioned that wonderful gig so I think you answered the question — I didn't even ask it.

DS: Wow. No but I've had steady jobs, anonymous type jobs in restaurants where I would meet — ooh sorry — it's meeting people and bonding in some cases. They become like best friends or kind of like family, and even traveling I got to go to England and started performing at Pizza on the Park in London, which was a place that Blossom Dearie played in and Dave Frishberg and lots of jazz people, some singers, and the ownership of that, let's say the circle of places became The Pizza Express Live and they have a couple of other places in London where jazz musicians play, and one called The Pheasantry which is a little bit more singer-friendly so I'm going to be there in September. But during the '90s, when I had these recordings coming out on Arbors and things were still a little easier to travel, and they had more jazz societies around the country. Britain is, you know, they love, particularly trad jazz, although they have great musicians there for everything. But I started developing what I was calling my U.K. Nooks and Crannies Tour. And I prided myself on playing places that even Brits never heard of. How do like Clethorps, which is up north. Sounds like a prehistoric animal.

MR: It does.

DS: Or, I played, I'm going, in fact I'm going to be going back there in Wales there's a lovely little area on the sea called Mumbles. And I met some of these people when they came to The Waldorf, and some have been enduring relationships.

MR: So when you go into a nook and cranny to play there's a moment where you walk up to the piano and you go [motions pressing a piano key]. See what it's going to sound like.

DS: Well it's gotten worse because at least — at that time most of the places did have a piano of sorts. Sometimes it was an upright but it was good, or okay, but now it's mostly, you know, keyboards. And they just assume that that's what it's going to be. And it's — well it's kind of hurt me because I don't — you asked me about my worst gig — I'll tell you about my worst gig which was a couple of summers ago, it was a birthday party for someone who knew a friend of mine, a fan of mine, who suggested, "Oh you'll love Daryl Sherman, she loves all — she can do jazz and she can play all your Broadway songs and stuff." It was at their home, a big estate in New Jersey. And they didn't have a piano. Well so I thought okay, I'm going to have to learn how to do this so maybe I should just experiment and try it. So I rented a keyboard, which is still heavy, and you have to have a sound system as well but fortunately in this case I didn't have to lug that, but just lugging the keyboard and all the accoutrements, it was heavy. And she said, "Oh don't worry, there'll be people to help with it." Nobody to help me. First, they wanted it outside so it was starting to rain but I set it up, someone had to help me. And then they went inside and this was an old house with little rooms with small doorways. And I'm not used to lugging it around. I was absolutely livid. And I don't know what she was thinking, because she wanted me to play and she wanted certain — she wanted like a Broadway medley. So I went to all the trouble of writing up names of songs for a sing-a-long and, you know, copying them and making them pretty and everything, and I had like fifty of them. Well what happened, I got into just an area that the piano would fit, but people were all seated in different rooms and there was nobody in my room. Oh, and the best part, someone finally saw that I was just fit to be tied, a very tall, part of the wait staff, big woman, "Would you like some help?" "Oh," I said, "you're my angel." I said, "Here, take the other side of this, it's very heavy." She said, "Just stand aside." She picks the whole piano up over her head like this and just walks through the room.

MR: That's a strong angel.

DS: So that, but I've never been — I mean I've had worse situations probably but still, that was one that I was just so angry at myself for taking it, and angry about the woman who hired me and her sons and everything were just so disregard anything — so I played anyway, even though they couldn't hear me. And at the end, when we were ready to leave I gave the fifty copies to the, you know, to the birthday girl who just kind of looks down, she says, "Well maybe next year." Never again.

MR: "My phone's going to be busy next year."

DS: Never again.

MR: Yeah. I want to wrap up with a question that might be worthwhile for up-and-coming musicians. Most of us have lists of players to call when we get a gig and we have to

assemble a group. And what kind of behavior — either musical or otherwise — would make you move someone down your list as opposed to up your list?

DS: That's an interesting question. Rarely would it happen. Maybe something that was treasonous like I mean it hasn't happened, but if someone was trying to hustle a gig, I don't know. If someone got terribly drunk and passed out or did something I might have to be. I don't know. Huh.

MR: Well musically —

DS: Well now actually — or just someone who was clearly not — not getting my groove and not, but you know, then again I'm not — particularly at this time of life I'm not, you know, I'm not so easily destined to be hiring somebody that I don't know. I might sometime, and I should because it's always nice to play with other people. But you want your comfort level. And sometimes things go wrong even with them and you get, you know like why did he do that to me. And why did he blah-blah-blah. But still, you know, you're like a dysfunctional family. I have, I have different people that I like to use to emphasize different things. Like I have Boots Malison who has five strings, he remembers everything I played in 1980, he's got a beautiful sound, he's quick, he can read everything. And yet my first bass player when I came to New York was Jay Leonhart.

MR: A good place to start.

DS: Who was very busy in the studios. Yeah. Yeah. He's going to be going to London, we're going to do the Blossom/Frishberg show again. And he sings. So that adds another entertainment dimension. And now I have a twin act. Peter and Will Anderson, or Will and Peter Anderson went through the Juilliard School program. I met them because one of my friends was the director of a theater, 59 — East 59th . He discovered them busking in Central Park and hired them to play one night a week at the bar of the theater. And from that they, you know, they're doing everything all over. They each play multi reeds, they're smart, they're adorable, they're identical but you can tell them a little bit apart. And I did an Artie Shaw program with them, that's how we got to know each other. And I sang, and we didn't talk about that but I sang with Artie Shaw but not in the '30s, even though it may sound that way, in the '80s. But what's fun is first of all they're so quick. Even — they know a lot of the old songs. They've been playing regularly with Vince Giordano and the Nighthawks or David Ostwalt who is at Birdland playing the Louis Armstrong, so they know the whole tradition. But they can do all sorts of things. They read, and so I love just the three of us not even a bass, not even a drummer. And we'll be at Mezzrow on the 18th , June 18. And we did something a month or so ago. And I'll give them a song, I'll indicate — sometimes I'll write out a little line for them to play, once in a while. And sometimes we just wing it. And they — because they just have this, well

because they're exceptional musicians, but I think they just have this twinny thing. They must. It is extraordinary, and the way they play together. And it sounds like I'm singing with an orchestra. And they're cute. They're so — they're actually over 30 now, and they're both fathers of now two children.

MR: Wow.

DS: But I love doing that. And it's so stimulating.

MR: Well this has been a wonderful conversation, and I make an observation that your father, who did get to hear you, must be very proud. He was proud and he probably still is.

DS: Oh, I hope so. I hope so. He's up there. Just before he died, bless their hearts, the Arbors people released a recording of live performances at my hometown jazz emporium, Chan's, through a few years when he was actually at his best on the trombone, and every time I'd come I'd have Warren Vache or maybe — oh Loren Schoenberg and some — Joe Cohn and all different people for him, Dan Barrett, and he loved that. And so it became an album and it's still out there. On his birthday the year after he died I was playing in London and there was a program at one of the record stores. They did concerts there. But I — so I just looked up and I saw on the shelf of albums displayed my father's picture with the trombone on the front of the album. And I just melted. And I just — you know that's him up in heaven.

MR: Well I hope you have a wonderful gig this afternoon and I'm going to put in a request for "Once in a While."

DS: Okay.

MR: And I especially hope your gig on Friday, which is your birthday — maybe you could play "Happy Birthday" in all twelve keys, see if anybody notices.

DS: Oh twelve — you know I've never counted how many there are. I definitely avoid certain ones. But thank you. I — you know, I play it as safe as I can. You? I don't know, it's your fault, you're just so easy to talk with. [sings] "You'd be so easy to talk with."

MR: Thank you for that.

DS: Thank you. Come visit sometime.

MR: All right. I'd love to see you live and thanks a lot.

DS: I'll keep in touch.

MR: I'll just pause this and we'll say our good-byes.